WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

GAMBIA

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Greater Banjul Area (Banjul, Kanifing)	Capital and main commercial centre; seat of government, the central bank and the banking sector, with leasehold land titles more established than elsewhere	Financial services, trade, real estate, professional services
Port of Banjul and Half-Die container terminal	The country's only seaport and a regional gateway for re-exports to Mali, Guinea-Bissau and southern Senegal; rehabilitation under a 30-year concession is complete and a new Half-Die container terminal is in use	Port logistics, warehousing, re-export trade
Sanyang (West Coast Region)	Site of a planned deep-sea port under the same concession, with site studies now under way following assignment of the land lease in March 2026	Port development, construction, marine services
Atlantic coast tourism strip (Kololi, Kotu, Bijilo)	Heart of a tourism sector worth an estimated 18–20% of GDP, with arrivals rising to 233,113 and a further 15% increase forecast for the 2026/27 season	Hotels, hospitality, aviation services, leisure real estate
Brikama and Jambur (West Coast Region)	Location of the 23 MWp Jambur solar plant with 8 MWh of battery storage and an OMVG regional grid substation	Renewable energy, agro-processing, light manufacturing
Soma and Farafenni (Trans-Gambia corridor)	Central river crossing on the corridor between northern and southern Senegal, with a 225 kV OMVG substation importing power from the regional grid	Transit logistics, energy, cross-border trade
Kaur and Basse (River Gambia, east)	Agricultural heartland and planned inland logistics platforms under the port concession, connecting river trade with the eastern regions	Groundnuts, cashew, horticulture, river logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Gambia Investment and Export Promotion Agency (GIEPA), the national one-stop agency for foreign investors, issuing Special Investment Certificates (SICs) for qualifying projects under the GIEPA Act 2015
- GIEPA Amendment Bill 2025, backed by the National Assembly at Second Reading in March 2026, which modernises the investment framework, aligns it with the AfCFTA investment protocol and makes incentive administration clearer and more transparent

- Special Export Promotion Zone licences from GIEPA for export-oriented operations, alongside SICs held by 73 companies with a combined investment portfolio of $268 million in 2023
- Market-determined dalasi exchange rate overseen by the Central Bank of The Gambia, with profits, dividends and capital repatriated through commercial banks
- Broadly open foreign ownership, with restrictions limited to a few sectors such as foreign exchange bureaux, television broadcasting and defence, and an English common-law legal system with ICSID membership
- Concession and public-private partnership route, illustrated by the 30-year Banjul and Sanyang port concession effective February 2025 and power purchase arrangements with the national utility NAWEC
- Co-investment alongside development partners, including the IMF-supported ECF and RSF programmes, World Bank budget and energy financing, and EIB and EU co-financing of the $165 million Jambur solar project

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

The Gambia in October 2026 offers a decade of steady growth, falling inflation and an active reform agenda. The economy grew by around 6% in 2025 (5.7–6.0% according to the central bank and the IMF), extending an average of 5% a year since the 2017 democratic transition, and growth of 4.7–5.8% is projected for 2026. Inflation fell from 10.2% in December 2024 to 6.4% in January 2026, allowing the central bank to cut its policy rate from 16% to 14%; it stood at 7.0% in July 2026 as global oil prices rose. Gross reserves reached $563.9 million at end-July 2026, equal to 4.3 months of imports, and remittances rose 12.4% to a record $872 million in 2025. FDI inflows were $232 million in 2024, with an inward stock of about $1.9 billion. The banking sector is well capitalised (capital adequacy of 25.5%), and the IMF completed its fifth ECF review in July 2026, noting that the economy "continues to grow strongly".

The Gambia's main structural challenge is public debt, estimated at 72–76% of GDP in 2025, which the IMF and World Bank assess as carrying a high risk of debt distress, alongside a narrow tax base averaging 10.3% of GDP. The direction of travel is positive: the debt ratio fell from 73.6% in 2024 to 71.8% at end-2025 according to the Ministry of Finance, and is projected at 68.8% in 2026. The overall fiscal deficit narrowed to 1.7% of GDP in the first half of 2026 from 3.1% a year earlier, state-owned enterprises returned a combined net profit of D2.5 billion in 2025, and the World Bank estimates that closing tax gaps could raise 3–4% of GDP in revenue. With IMF, World Bank and EU support anchoring reform, the need to finance infrastructure through private capital rather than public borrowing is creating concrete opportunities for investors in energy, ports and tourism.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Public debt and fiscal space	Public debt of around 72–76% of GDP limits public investment, although the ratio is falling and the fiscal deficit is narrowing under an IMF-supported programme	Structure projects around concessions, PPPs and DFI co-financing; fiscal consolidation is steadily improving sovereign creditworthiness
Imported fuel and energy prices	Higher global oil prices lifted inflation to 7.0% in July 2026, with transport inflation at 16.5%	Central bank policy remains data-dependent and reserves cover 4.3 months of imports; the shift to solar and regional grid power is a growing investment opportunity
December 2026 presidential election	A competitive multi-candidate election is scheduled for 5 December 2026, with the IMF programme including an election-year spending cap	The Gambia has held peaceful elections since 2017; time major commitments around the electoral calendar and engage across the policy spectrum
Power supply and infrastructure gaps	Power interruptions and road conditions in the rainy season can raise operating costs outside the Greater Banjul Area	The Jambur solar plant, OMVG power imports and donor-funded grid upgrades are improving supply, creating openings for independent power and logistics investors
Project delivery timelines	The Sanyang deep-sea port has been delayed by land-lease and site-study issues on both sides, which the	Use milestone-based contracts and clear land and permit conditions; Banjul port rehabilitation was delivered on schedule,

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	government has openly acknowledged	showing that concessions can perform
Land tenure and registration	Land outside Greater Banjul is largely held under customary tenure and records remain partly manual, which can lead to competing claims	Conduct thorough title due diligence, prefer registered leaseholds and work through GIEPA and the Department of Lands for site allocation
Coastal erosion and climate exposure	Beach erosion and flood risk affect tourism assets and coastal infrastructure	The IMF Resilience and Sustainability Facility and World Bank coastal-management reforms support adaptation, creating opportunities in climate-resilient construction

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

The Gambia's risk profile is that of a small, open and reform-minded economy with a consistent growth record, improving macroeconomic management and strong backing from international partners. Inflation has fallen from double digits, the central bank has begun easing, reserves cover more than four months of imports and record remittances provide a dependable source of foreign exchange. Public debt is the principal constraint, and the IMF and World Bank continue to rate the risk of debt distress as high; however, the debt ratio is declining, the fiscal deficit is narrowing and SOE finances have turned to profit. The presidential election on 5 December 2026 is a key milestone, and the country's record of peaceful elections since 2017 supports continuity in its partnerships with the IMF, World Bank and EU. Investors should plan for some exposure to imported-fuel prices and project-delivery timelines, while taking comfort from the market-determined exchange rate, open foreign-ownership regime and growing pipeline of private-sector opportunities in energy, logistics and tourism.

MARKET ACCESS

The Gambia is a member of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), a State Party to the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), and a member of the WTO. Its position on the River Gambia and the Atlantic coast makes the Port of Banjul a natural gateway for re-export trade: in 2024, Mali (25.2%), Guinea-Bissau (14.8%) and Senegal (11.7%) together took more than half of exports, with China (36.3%) the largest single market, principally for groundnuts. The Trans-Gambia corridor through Soma and Farafenni connects northern and southern Senegal, while the OMVG interconnection links the country to the regional power grid. Trade with the UK totalled £174 million in 2025, and English as the official business language, together with long-standing tourism links to the UK and Northern Europe, gives British and European investors a familiar operating environment.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Adama Barrow)	Sets national economic priorities under the Recovery-Focused National Development Plan 2023–2027 (YIRIWAA) and leads relations with key international partners	Primary reference point for strategic direction, particularly through the December 2026 election cycle
Gambia Investment and Export Promotion Agency (GIEPA)	National investment and export promotion agency; issues Special Investment Certificates and export licences, and will implement the updated investment framework	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and site facilitation
Central Bank of The Gambia	Monetary authority; sets the policy rate (14%), manages reserves and supervises a well-capitalised banking sector	Relevant for currency, repatriation and banking-sector matters
Ministry of Finance and Economic Affairs	Manages the budget, debt strategy and the IMF and World Bank programmes; Minister Seedy Keita chairs the ECOWAS Bank for Investment and Development (EBID) Board of Governors	Key counterpart for PPP structuring, fiscal incentives and DFI co-financing

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Gambia Ports Authority (GPA)	Guarantor and shareholder in the Banjul and Sanyang port concession, and steward of the country's re-export gateway	Essential partner for logistics, shipping and port-related investment
National Water and Electricity Company (NAWEC)	State utility and offtaker for power generation, operating the Jambur solar plant and OMVG regional power imports	Key counterpart for independent power, solar and energy-efficiency projects
Gambia Tourism Board	Promotes and regulates the tourism sector, estimated at 18–20% of GDP, and forecasts a 15% rise in arrivals for 2026/27	Relevant for hotel, aviation and leisure investment and destination marketing

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Gambia Chamber of Commerce and Industry (GCCI) is the main private-sector body, alongside sector associations such as the Gambia Hotel Association. GIEPA hosts investor forums and stakeholder briefings for certificate holders and has partnered with the OIC's Islamic Centre for Development of Trade on the Banjul Investment Forum. The World Bank, IMF, European Investment Bank, European Union and African Development Bank all run active programmes covering budget support, energy, climate resilience and private-sector development, and the ECOWAS Bank for Investment and Development offers a regional financing channel. The diaspora is an important investment partner, with diaspora direct investment estimated at $300 million in 2024 — around 30% higher than FDI — measured through a new Diaspora Direct Investment Index that The Gambia piloted in 2026.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

The Gambia suits investors who value a stable, English-speaking, common-law environment and a strong development-partner presence: tourism and hospitality investors building on a sector worth around a fifth of GDP and a growing season; renewable-energy and independent power investors responding to rising demand and donor-backed grid upgrades; logistics and trade investors positioned around the Port of Banjul and regional re-export flows; and agribusiness investors in groundnuts, cashew, horticulture and fisheries. Financial-services and fintech firms can serve record remittance flows of $872 million, while diaspora investors and impact and DFI-backed funds are well placed to partner on infrastructure and SME growth.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage GIEPA and confirm the incentive framework
Open dialogue with GIEPA on Special Investment Certificate eligibility and the provisions of the GIEPA Amendment Bill as it completes its passage.

STEP 2: Align with development-partner programmes
Identify co-financing and risk-sharing opportunities with the World Bank, EIB, EU, AfDB and EBID in energy, climate resilience and private-sector development.

STEP 3: Plan commitments around the December 2026 election
Use the pre-election period for due diligence and relationship-building, and time major contractual commitments with the electoral calendar in mind.

STEP 4: Secure land and permits early
Carry out title due diligence, prefer registered leaseholds and build land-lease and permit milestones into project agreements.

STEP 5: Position for energy, port and tourism growth
Track the Banjul and Sanyang port concession, NAWEC power procurement and the 2026/27 tourism season for partnership and supply-chain opportunities.